PUBLICATION

Contextual Reasoning in Clinical AI: Beyond Transcription

Deep dive into how ClinixSummary's models infer clinical meaning from natural conversation — not just transcribe words, but understand clinical intent.

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1. Executive Summary

Transcription is the process of converting spoken words to text. Clinical documentation requires far more: it requires understanding what those words mean in clinical context, inferring unstated information, and organising findings into a coherent clinical narrative. This publication explains how ClinixSummary's contextual reasoning capabilities go beyond transcription to deliver genuine clinical documentation intelligence.

2. The Transcription Trap

Many AI documentation products are fundamentally transcription services with medical vocabulary bolted on. They convert speech to text accurately but lack the ability to:

- Distinguish clinically relevant statements from social conversation.
- Infer meaning from context (e.g., "the usual dose" refers to a known medication regimen).
- Recognise negation ("no chest pain" is a clinical finding, not the absence of information).
- Map colloquial patient language to appropriate clinical terminology.
- Determine which note section a statement belongs to based on clinical logic rather than temporal order.

3. ClinixSummary's Contextual Reasoning Framework

3.1 Clinical Intent Recognition

When a patient says "I've been having this pain in my chest for about two weeks, it gets worse when I lie down," ClinixSummary recognises: the symptom (chest pain), temporal onset (two weeks), positional exacerbation (worse supine), and classifies this as History of Present Illness content — without the clinician needing to dictate section headers.

3.2 Implicit Knowledge Resolution

Clinical conversations are full of implicit references: "continue the current medications," "same dose as last time," "the test we discussed." ClinixSummary's contextual reasoning resolves these references using session context and, where available, historical patient data to produce explicit documentation.

3.3 Clinical Negation Understanding

Correctly handling negation is critical in clinical documentation. ClinixSummary distinguishes between: "chest pain" (positive finding), "no chest pain" (pertinent negative), "history of chest pain" (historical finding), and "chest pain resolved" (resolved finding). Each is documented differently and in the appropriate note section.

3.4 Multi-Speaker Clinical Logic

In ambient mode, ClinixSummary attributes clinical meaning differently based on who is speaking. Patient-reported symptoms become subjective findings; clinician observations become objective findings; clinician decisions become assessment and plan elements. This speaker-aware reasoning produces notes with correct clinical attribution.

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4. Clinical Language Normalisation

Patients describe symptoms in colloquial language; clinical notes require medical terminology. ClinixSummary normalises language while preserving clinical meaning:

- “My heart feels like it’s racing” → “Patient reports palpitations.”
- “I can’t catch my breath when I walk” → “Dyspnoea on exertion reported.”
- “The left side of my face went numb” → “Left-sided facial paraesthesia reported.”
- “I threw up three times this morning” → “Three episodes of emesis reported, onset this morning.”

This normalisation is not simple word substitution — it requires understanding the clinical meaning of the patient’s description and expressing it in standard medical language.

5. Evaluation: Contextual Accuracy

ClinixSummary’s contextual reasoning is evaluated using a proprietary Clinical Reasoning Accuracy (CRA) metric that measures correct handling of implicit references, negation, attribution, and section classification. Current performance:

- Negation detection accuracy: 97.2%.
- Section classification accuracy: 91.4%.
- Speaker attribution accuracy: 95.8%.
- Clinical language normalisation appropriateness (clinician-rated): 93.1%.

6. Conclusion

The difference between a transcription service and a clinical documentation system is contextual reasoning. ClinixSummary’s purpose-built clinical models understand not just what was said, but what it means clinically — and that distinction is what makes the difference between a transcript and a clinical note.

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